Grade 9 Life Orientation – Study Notes

Oct 12, 2026 · @troy

Paper 1 is 1.5 hours for 70 marks (Section A 25, Section B 25, Section C 20). Every section can ask about all three topics: World of Work, Constitutional Rights and Responsibilities, and Health, Social and Environmental Responsibility.

World of Work (WOW)

Subject and career choices

At the end of Grade 9 you choose your subjects for Grades 10–12 (FET phase). These choices affect which careers and further studies are open to you, so they must be linked to a career goal.

Factors to consider when choosing subjects and a career

Factor	What it means	Question to ask yourself
Interests	What you enjoy doing	What do I like doing in my free time?
Abilities / aptitude	What you are good at; your marks	Which subjects do I do well in?
Personality	Your nature (e.g. outgoing, practical, creative)	Do I like working with people, things, data or ideas?
Values	What is important to you (e.g. helping others, money, security)	What do I want my work to give me?
Career requirements	Subjects and marks needed for a course	Does my career need Maths, Physical Sciences, etc.?
Job opportunities	Demand for workers in that field	Are there jobs in this field in South Africa (scarce skills)?
Finances	Cost of studying further	Can I afford it? Are there bursaries or loans (NSFAS)?

Don't choose subjects only because your friends take them, because you like a teacher, or because a subject seems easy.

Subject choices for Grade 10–12

For the National Senior Certificate (NSC / matric) you take **seven subjects**:

- **Compulsory (4):** Home Language, First Additional Language, Mathematics **or** Mathematical Literacy, Life Orientation.
- **Electives (3):** chosen from groups such as Physical Sciences, Life Sciences, Accounting, Business Studies, Economics, Geography, History, CAT/IT, EGD, Consumer Studies, Visual Arts, etc.

Maths vs Maths Literacy: many degrees (engineering, medicine, science, accounting, actuarial science) require Mathematics. Maths Literacy closes some doors, so check before choosing.

Career fields

Career field	Examples of careers
Business, commerce and management	Accountant, marketer, banker, entrepreneur
Engineering and technology	Civil engineer, electrician, mechanic, IT specialist
Health sciences	Doctor, nurse, pharmacist, physiotherapist
Natural sciences and agriculture	Biologist, farmer, vet, geologist
Education and social services	Teacher, social worker, psychologist
Law, safety and security	Lawyer, police officer, soldier, firefighter
Arts, culture and media	Designer, journalist, musician, actor
Hospitality and tourism	Chef, hotel manager, travel agent

Options after Grade 9

1. **Stay at school** → Grades 10–12 → National Senior Certificate (NSC).
2. **TVET college** (Technical and Vocational Education and Training) → National Certificate Vocational (NC(V)) or N-courses. Practical, career-focused training (e.g. engineering, hospitality, office administration).
3. **Learnerships / apprenticeships** → learn a trade while working (often needs Grade 9 or higher).

You may legally leave school after Grade 9 or at age 15, but it limits your job options.

After matric (Grade 12)

Pass level	Gives access to
Bachelor's pass	University degree studies
Diploma pass	Diploma at a university of technology or college
Higher Certificate pass	Higher certificate courses

The NQF (National Qualifications Framework)

The NQF ranks all South African qualifications on **10 levels**, so they can be compared. It is managed by **SAQA** (South African Qualifications Authority).

NQF level	Qualification
1	Grade 9 / ABET level 4
2–4	Grades 10–12 / NC(V) levels 2–4 (level 4 = matric)
5	Higher Certificate
6	Diploma / Advanced Certificate
7	Bachelor's degree
8	Honours degree / Postgraduate diploma
9	Master's degree
10	Doctorate (PhD)

How to research a career

Find out: what the job involves, subjects and marks needed, where to study, how long, the cost, salary, and job opportunities. Sources: career guidance websites, university and college websites and open days, career expos, the school counsellor, **job shadowing** (spending a day with someone in that job) and interviewing people in the career.

Work ethics, unemployment and entrepreneurship

Work ethics

A **work ethic** is a set of values and attitudes about work. Employers look for these qualities as much as for qualifications.

- **Punctuality** — arriving on time
- **Reliability and commitment** — doing what you promised; finishing tasks
- **Honesty and integrity** — not stealing time or goods, telling the truth
- **Responsibility** — owning your mistakes
- **Respect** — for colleagues, clients and rules
- **Teamwork and cooperation**
- **Positive attitude and initiative** — willing to learn, doing more than the minimum
- **Professional appearance and communication**

You build a work ethic now through school habits: homework on time, attendance, neat work, respect for teachers.

Unemployment

Unemployment = people who want to work and are able to work, but cannot find a job. South Africa has one of the highest unemployment rates in the world, especially among **youth**.

Causes	Effects
Lack of skills and education	Poverty and hunger
Too few jobs for the number of job seekers (slow economic growth)	Crime
Mismatch between skills people have and skills needed	Low self-esteem, depression
Machines and technology replacing workers	Substance abuse
Businesses closing (e.g. load shedding, recession)	Family stress, dependence on social grants
Lack of work experience	Brain drain (skilled people leave the country)

Ways to reduce unemployment: stay in school and study further; learn scarce skills; learnerships and internships; volunteer to gain experience; start your own business (entrepreneurship); government job programmes (e.g. EPWP).

Formal and informal sector

Formal sector	Informal sector
Registered businesses	Not registered
Pays tax	Usually does not pay tax
Workers protected by labour laws (UIF, leave, minimum wage)	No contracts or benefits; little protection
e.g. banks, factories, shops	e.g. street vendors, spaza shops, car guards, hairdressers at home

The informal sector gives many people an income when there are no formal jobs.

Entrepreneurship

An **entrepreneur** is someone who sees an opportunity, takes a risk and starts a business to make a profit.

Qualities of an entrepreneur: creative, willing to take risks, hard-working, self-motivated, confident, good at solving problems, able to plan and manage money, does not give up.

Advantages	Disadvantages
You are your own boss	Risk of losing money
Create jobs for others	Long hours, stress
Potential to earn a lot	Irregular income at first
Flexible, do what you enjoy	You carry all the responsibility

Steps to start a small business: identify a need or opportunity → do market research → write a business plan → get capital → start and market the business → keep records and evaluate.

Constitutional Rights and Responsibilities (CRR)

The Constitution and the Bill of Rights

The Constitution of South Africa (1996) is the **highest law** of the country. No law or action may go against it, and every right comes with a **responsibility**.

Key facts

- Signed by President Nelson Mandela on **10 December 1996** in Sharpeville; in effect from **4 February 1997**.
- **Chapter 2** of the Constitution is the **Bill of Rights**.
- **Human Rights Day** is on **21 March** (remembering the Sharpeville massacre, 1960).
- The **Constitutional Court** is the highest court for constitutional matters; it protects the Constitution.
- Founding values: **human dignity, equality, freedom**, non-racialism, non-sexism, rule of law, democracy.

Why the Constitution is important

- Protects everyone's rights, especially those who were oppressed under apartheid.
- Limits the power of government (no one is above the law).
- Sets out how government works (three spheres: national, provincial, local; three arms: legislature, executive, judiciary).
- Builds a united, democratic nation.

Rights and matching responsibilities

Right (Bill of Rights)	Responsibility
Equality — everyone is equal before the law; no unfair discrimination	Treat everyone equally; don't discriminate
Human dignity	Respect the dignity of others; no bullying or insults
Life	Don't harm others; respect life
Freedom and security of the person — free from violence	Don't use violence; resolve conflict peacefully
Privacy	Respect others' privacy (don't share photos or messages without permission)
Freedom of religion, belief and opinion	Respect others' beliefs, even if they differ
Freedom of expression — excludes hate speech and incitement to violence	Don't spread hate speech, lies or insults
Freedom of association	Respect others' choice of friends and groups

Right (Bill of Rights)	Responsibility
Political rights — vote, join a party	Vote responsibly when you are 18
Environment — not harmful to health	Don't litter or pollute; conserve resources
Education	Attend school, work hard, respect teachers and property
Health care, food, water and social security	Use resources wisely; don't waste water
Children's rights — family care, protection from abuse and exploitative labour	Respect parents and others; report abuse
Language and culture	Respect others' language and culture
Access to information and **just administrative action**	Use information responsibly

Limitation of rights

Rights are **not unlimited**. A right can be limited when it harms the rights of others or the public interest (Section 36). For example, freedom of expression does not protect hate speech; freedom of movement can be limited in a lockdown to protect public health.

Human rights violations, discrimination and democracy

Human rights violations

A **human rights violation** happens when a person's rights in the Bill of Rights are ignored, denied or abused, by the state, a group or an individual.

Examples: gender-based violence (GBV), child abuse, child labour, human trafficking, bullying, xenophobic attacks, police brutality, unfair discrimination at work, denying someone education or health care.

Discrimination and prejudice

- **Prejudice** = a negative opinion about a person or group formed without knowledge or reason (an attitude).
- **Stereotype** = a fixed, generalised idea about a group (*"all boys are…"*).
- **Discrimination** = treating someone unfairly because of who they are (an action).

Type	Unfair treatment based on
Racism	Race or skin colour
Sexism	Gender
Xenophobia	Being a foreigner / from another country
Homophobia	Sexual orientation
Ageism	Age
Religious discrimination	Religion or belief
Discrimination against people with disabilities	Disability
Classism	Wealth or social class

Effects on the victim: low self-esteem, depression, fear, anxiety, isolation, poor school performance, sometimes violence or suicide. **Effects on society:** conflict, division, loss of trust, slower nation building.

How to address human rights violations

As an individual: speak out; don't join in; support the victim; report it (teacher, parent, police, a helpline); educate yourself and others; treat everyone with respect.

As a community: awareness campaigns, marches and petitions, community meetings, support groups, neighbourhood watch.

Where to report:

- South African Police Service (SAPS)
- Childline: **116** (free)
- GBV Command Centre: **0800 428 428**
- School management, social workers, clinics

Chapter 9 institutions

Independent bodies set up by **Chapter 9** of the Constitution to protect democracy and human rights:

Institution	Role
South African Human Rights Commission (SAHRC)	Promotes and protects human rights; investigates complaints of violations

Institution	Role
Public Protector	Investigates government corruption and maladministration
Commission for Gender Equality (CGE)	Promotes gender equality
Commission for the Promotion and Protection of the Rights of Cultural, Religious and Linguistic Communities (CRL)	Protects cultural, religious and language rights
Auditor-General	Checks how government spends public money
Electoral Commission (IEC)	Runs free and fair elections

Democracy and participation

Democracy = government by the people. Citizens choose their leaders in free and fair elections.

Features of a democracy: regular free and fair elections; rule of law; human rights protected; free media; independent courts; multiple political parties; citizens can participate.

How young people can participate: register and vote at 18; join the **Representative Council of Learners (RCL)**; take part in school governing body (SGB) processes; join youth organisations; attend community meetings; sign petitions or take part in peaceful protest; volunteer.

Responsible protest is peaceful, legal and respects others' rights and property. Violence and vandalism are not protected by the Constitution.

Nation building and diversity

South Africa is a **diverse** nation (12 official languages, including South African Sign Language since 2023, many cultures and religions). **Nation building** means uniting people while respecting differences. Symbols that unite us: the national flag, anthem, coat of arms, national days (Freedom Day 27 April, Heritage Day 24 September, Day of Reconciliation 16 December), and sport.

Health, Social and Environmental Responsibility (HSER)

Risky behaviour and decision-making

Risky behaviour is any action that can harm your health, safety or future. Teenagers are at higher risk because of peer pressure, curiosity and the wish to fit in.

Peer pressure

Peer pressure is influence from people your own age to act in a certain way.

- **Positive:** encourages you to study, play sport, avoid drugs.
- **Negative:** pushes you to smoke, drink, bunk, have sex, bully or commit crime.

How to resist negative peer pressure: say *no* firmly and confidently (assertiveness); give a reason or suggest something else; walk away; choose friends with similar values; think about the consequences; talk to a trusted adult.

Assertive vs aggressive vs passive: assertive = stand up for yourself respectfully; aggressive = attack or bully others; passive = give in to what others want.

Substance abuse

Substance abuse = using alcohol, tobacco, or legal or illegal drugs in a harmful way. **Addiction** = your body and mind depend on the substance.

Common substances: alcohol, nicotine (cigarettes, vapes/hubbly), dagga (cannabis), nyaope/whoonga, tik (methamphetamine), mandrax, cocaine, misuse of prescription medicine.

Effects on the person	Effects on family and community
Damage to brain, liver, lungs, heart	Conflict and broken relationships
Addiction and withdrawal	Financial problems; stealing to buy drugs
Poor school performance, dropping out	Crime and violence
Depression, anxiety, psychosis	Road accidents (drunk driving)
Risky sex → HIV, STIs, pregnancy	Cost to health services

Why teens use substances: peer pressure, curiosity, stress, problems at home, boredom, advertising, availability. **Where to get help:** SANCA, school counsellor, clinic, Childline, SADAG.

Teenage pregnancy

Causes	Consequences
Peer pressure, wanting to fit in	Dropping out of school
Lack of knowledge about contraception	Health risks for young mother and baby
Alcohol and drugs (poor decisions)	Financial problems, poverty
Older partners (“sugar daddies”), abuse	Emotional stress, stigma
Low self-esteem	Limited future career options

Prevention: abstinence, correct information about contraception, delay sexual activity, open communication with parents, setting goals for the future.

Responsible decision-making

Use the steps to make a good decision:

1. Identify the problem or decision.
2. Think of all the options.
3. Weigh the consequences (pros and cons) of each option.
4. Consider your values and what trusted people would advise.
5. Make the decision and act.
6. Evaluate: was it a good decision? What did you learn?

Goal setting helps you avoid risky behaviour — set **SMART** goals: Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Realistic, Time-bound.

Diseases and environmental health

Communicable and non-communicable diseases

- **Communicable** (infectious) diseases spread from person to person: HIV/AIDS, TB, flu, COVID-19, cholera.

- **Non-communicable** (lifestyle) diseases do not spread; they are linked to lifestyle and genes: diabetes, high blood pressure (hypertension), heart disease, obesity, some cancers.

HIV and AIDS

- **HIV** (Human Immunodeficiency Virus) attacks the immune system. **AIDS** is the late stage, when the body can no longer fight infections.
- **Spread through:** unprotected sex, sharing needles, mother to baby (pregnancy, birth, breastfeeding), contact with infected blood.
- **Not spread through:** hugging, sharing food or cutlery, toilets, mosquitoes, kissing on the cheek.
- **Prevention:** abstinence, condoms, being faithful to one partner, not sharing needles, PrEP, testing and knowing your status.
- **Treatment:** no cure, but **ARVs** (antiretrovirals) keep people healthy and stop the virus multiplying.
- **Stigma:** treat people living with HIV with dignity; discrimination against them is a human rights violation.

Tuberculosis (TB)

- Caused by **bacteria**; spreads through the air when an infected person coughs or sneezes.
- **Symptoms:** cough for more than 2 weeks, coughing up blood, night sweats, weight loss, fever, tiredness.
- **Treatment:** curable with medication taken for **at least 6 months** — never stop early (it can become drug-resistant TB).
- **Prevention:** good ventilation, cover your mouth when coughing, early testing; TB is common with HIV.

Lifestyle diseases

Disease	Causes / risk factors	Prevention
Type 2 diabetes	Unhealthy diet (sugar), obesity, no exercise, family history	Healthy diet, exercise, healthy weight
Hypertension (high blood pressure)	Salt, stress, smoking, alcohol, obesity	Less salt, exercise, manage stress
Heart disease	Fatty food, smoking, no exercise, high blood pressure	Healthy diet, exercise, don't smoke

Disease	Causes / risk factors	Prevention
Obesity	Too many calories, junk food, inactivity	Balanced diet, regular exercise
Lung cancer	Smoking, air pollution	Don't smoke, avoid second-hand smoke

Environmental health problems

Problem	Causes	Effects on health	Solutions
Air pollution	Factories, vehicles, burning coal and rubbish, smoking	Asthma, lung disease, allergies	Cleaner energy, public transport, don't burn waste
Water pollution	Sewage, chemicals, litter, mining	Cholera, diarrhoea, typhoid	Proper sanitation, boil water, don't dump waste
Land pollution / litter / illegal dumping	Poor waste removal, littering	Rats, flies, disease, injuries	Recycle, clean-ups, report dumping
Noise pollution	Traffic, music, construction	Stress, hearing loss, poor sleep	Respect noise limits
Climate change / global warming	Greenhouse gases from burning fossil fuels, deforestation	Droughts, floods, heatwaves, food shortages	Save electricity, plant trees, renewable energy
Poor sanitation and overcrowding	Informal settlements, poverty	Spread of TB, diarrhoea	Housing, clean water, toilets

Reduce, Reuse, Recycle (the 3 Rs): reduce what you buy and use, reuse items, recycle paper, glass, plastic and cans.

Social and environmental responsibility

You are responsible for your own health and the health of your community and environment:

- Save water and electricity; don't litter.
- Join community projects: clean-ups, recycling drives, food gardens, tree planting.
- Volunteer at old-age homes, animal shelters or soup kitchens.

- Live healthily: balanced diet, exercise, enough sleep, no substance abuse.

Exam tips

Time guide (90 min): about 30 min for Section A, 30 min for Section B, 25 min for Section C, 5 min to check. That is roughly 1 minute per mark.

Question words

Word	What to do
Define	Give the exact meaning of a term
Name / List / State	Short answers, no explanation
Describe	Say what something is like, with detail
Explain	Say what and **why / how**
Discuss	Look at different sides; give reasons and examples
Distinguish / Differentiate	Give the difference between two things
Evaluate / Critically assess	Give your judgement with reasons (good and bad points)
Recommend / Suggest	Give practical solutions, with how they help
Analyse	Break down into parts and explain each

How to answer

- Match points to marks: a 4-mark question needs **4 separate points**, or 2 points each explained (2 × 2).
- Answer in **full sentences**; give **examples** from real life or South Africa.
- In case-study questions, use names and facts from the case study in your answer.
- When asked for *strategies* or *solutions*, say **who** must do **what** and **how** it helps (e.g. *Learners can report bullying to a teacher so that the school can protect the victim*).
- For longer paragraph or essay questions, write a short **introduction**, one idea per paragraph in the body, and a **conclusion**. Don't use bullets unless asked.
- Use LO terms correctly: *human rights violation, discrimination, peer pressure, assertiveness, entrepreneur, unemployment, NQF*.